



OPPOSITION PARTY LEGISLATORS AT A SIT-IN AFTER BOYCOTTING THE AMENDMENT BILL

ruling parties are appointed as the president and members of the TDB.

Though most Hindu groups, including the Nair Service Society (NSS) of the upper caste Nair community, oppose the new Bill, the state Government has found solace in support from powerful backward communities like the Ezhavas as well as from the SC because of the Bill's provision of reserving a seat in the Board for them. The Bill also reserves two seats for women. "The Bill ends the monopoly of the upper castes and men in temple administration," says Vellappally Natesan, general secretary of the powerful Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam (SNDP) of the Ezhavas. Natesan also welcomes the provision on

handing over the appointment of the employees of temple administration to the Public Service Commission. "For long, appointments were a milch cow for political parties," he adds. The TDB alone has more than 2,000 employees. "Backward castes constitute more than 50 per cent of the Hindus and it is their offerings that fill the temple coffers. Hence, we represent a larger number of the Hindu community than the upper castes which are only 15 per cent," he says.

Natesan has also lambasted Muslim and Christian organisations for opposing the Bill. "What right do they have to meddle in Hindu affairs?" he asks. Muslim groups like the Muslim Sunni Yuvajana Sangham and the Nadvathul Mujahideen have urged the Government not to hurt

Sticking Points

Key provisions that have been included in the Bill

- Provides for the reservation of a seat for the Scheduled Castes and two for women.
- Raises TDB membership from three to seven.
- Gives the Government the right to summon records and institute complaints against the boards.
- The Government can dismiss the boards if an inquiry confirms any irregularity.
- Entrusts all appointments in the administrative department to the state PSC.

Hindu sentiments by bulldozing the Bill through. "The Government should try for a consensus among the Hindu community, however difficult it may be," says Kanthapuram Abubaker Maulvi, a powerful supremo of the state's Sunnis.

Despite such claims, the opposition to the Bill appears to have put the government on the backfoot. The Bill's movement in the Assembly has been delayed much and it has now been referred to a legislative subjects committee. The coming elections to the local self-government bodies too have forced the government to put the Bill on the backburner, especially since the ruling LDF's popularity has hit rock bottom. But this has angered the SNDP. "The Government appears to have chickened out in the face of upper caste opposition. The new Minister Ramachandran, who handles the temple administration portfolio, is a mole of the upper castes," says Natesan. Caught between the two groups, the Amendment Act seems to be like an albatross around the Government's neck. ■



“It is a revolutionary Bill which ends the monopoly of upper castes and men in the administration of temples.”

VELLAPPALLY NATESAN
GENERAL SECRETARY, SNDP